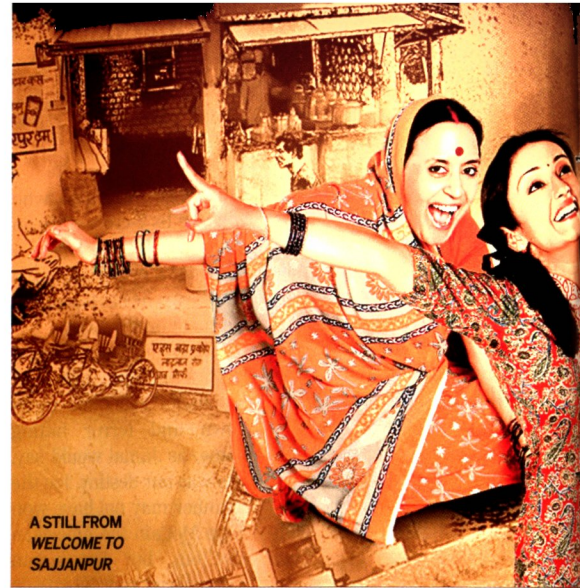


YEAR
2008

WHAT CLAIRVOYANCE
CAUSED NEERAJ PANDEY TO
MAKE A WEDNESDAY?
WHAT RIGHT TIMING GOT
SHYAM BENEGAL TO WRITE
A LOVE LETTER TO INDIA'S
FORGOTTEN VILLAGES IN
WELCOME TO SAJJANPUR?

began who was in a mood to listen to the grim reaper? Where was the interest in the small film that told a big tale? Monster noises were being made by manic moneymen, those corporate suits who had taken over the ramshackle distribution offices and walked all over the independent producer's assorted gold chains.

Bollywood was the new amusement park, where companies fresh from making money from London's AJM, were handing out exclusive deals to directors and brandishing hefty price tags to actors. Every day a new Rubicon was crossed. One day Aamir Khan's movie sold for Rs 93 crore. Another day, Akshay Kumar's services were hired for Rs 71 crore. Yet another day, a one-film Ranbir Kapoor was offered Rs 7

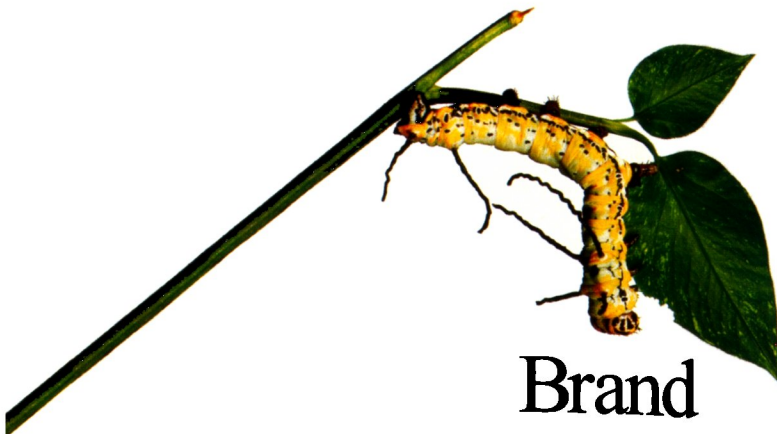


A STILL FROM
WELCOME TO
SAJJANPUR

crore for a movie. Movies were routinely released with over 1,500 prints and, in the case of *Ghajini*, in 22 countries. Even Himesh Reshammiya was emboldened to become Shah Rukh Khan, with his *Karzzzz* releasing with 1,200 prints.

Perhaps it was to be expected in an environment

where IPL was the ultimate tamasha, a combination of cricket and Bollywood, sport and celebrity, where as many turned out to watch what was happening on the turf as what was unfolding in the stands. After eight years, the monopoly of what had come to be known as the *saas-bahu* serials



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